

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN NICARAGUA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the lever that faced down the canal — a sustained rural movement rooted in land, water, and sovereignty, that marched roughly a hundred times and refused to consent to being displaced — and it names the tools you'll meet (the campesino movement, the sovereignty-and-water argument, the courts, the sheer refusal to yield land) in plain words. It is written with care, because the space to organise in Nicaragua has since narrowed sharply.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In 2013, the government granted a Chinese company a **fifty-year concession** to cut a **Grand Interoceanic Canal** across the country — some **two hundred and seventy-eight kilometres** from the Pacific to the Caribbean, straight through **Lake Nicaragua**, the nation's great freshwater reserve — with sweeping powers to expropriate land along its path. It was one of the largest megaprojects ever proposed in the Americas. But the people who lived on that land — **campesinos in the country's centre and south** — did not consent to being swept aside. Over the following years they **marched roughly a hundred times** against the concession, built a national movement, brought legal challenges, and refused, again and again, to give up their land. The **canal was never built. Not a single stretch was dug**. Farmers in rubber boots had, in large part, faced down a megaproject the government had staked its prestige on — and kept their land, their water, and their say.

The campesino movement against the canal drew on tools available to communities in Nicaragua — though today every one must be weighed against grave risk. Its bedrock was a refusal to consent to displacement: a community that will not sell or surrender its land is a practical, powerful obstacle to any project. **Land rights and titles**, where they hold, protect that ground in law. The **sovereignty-and-water argument** — a project drowning the nation's great freshwater reserve — is a powerful public case. The **courts** can be tried, where they still function. And **international human-rights and environmental bodies**, reachable through the diaspora and the press, can carry a cause past a closed space. But these tools have grave limits now, and this guide states them plainly. The canal's collapse was **not the movement's doing alone**: the project also foundered on its own **financing** — the Chinese backer's fortune collapsed — so the movement's pressure met a project already faltering, and a better-funded scheme would have been far harder to stop. Far more seriously, **the space to organise has since narrowed to almost nothing**. In the years after the 2018 uprising and its crushing, the government moved to **crush independent movements, jail and exile leaders, and outlaw civil-society groups**; peaceful protest that was possible during the canal fight can now bring **arrest, exile, or worse**. This guide therefore carries a warning it means with full weight: **in today's Nicaragua, protecting yourself and your community comes first**. So aim for what is realistically safe and possible, and never at the cost of your safety, because the openness that let the canal be marched against a hundred times is gone.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A megaproject with the government's prestige behind it looks unstoppable, but it depends on land it must take from people who can refuse — and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A Nicaraguan fight turns on the

refusal to yield land; on **land rights**; on the **sovereignty-and-water argument**; on the **courts**; and on **reaching the outside world**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and a community's refusal to give up its land is the one that helped stop the canal. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — but weigh every step against the danger.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend anything on this — above all your safety — work out your real situation:

- **If a project must take your land, refusing to yield it is a real obstacle** — campesinos who would not consent helped stop a two-hundred-kilometre canal.
- **If it threatens the nation's water and sovereignty, that's a powerful public case** — a canal through Lake Nicaragua's freshwater was indefensible.
- **If the courts and land rights still function for you, use them** — legal challenges were part of the canal fight.
- **If the space to organise is closed and dangerous — as it now is — protect yourself first** — the openness of the canal years is gone, and peaceful protest can now bring arrest or exile.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **root a fight in land, water, and the refusal to be displaced**, and **weigh every step against a danger that is now severe** — because in today's Nicaragua, your safety and your community's come before any tactic.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and, above all, what is safe.

Who Actually Decides

The **government** drives megaprojects and now tolerates little opposition; independent institutions are largely captured, and the courts often serve power. But a project that must **take land** depends on people who can refuse; **land rights** still hold some ground; the **sovereignty-and-water** case still moves the public and the world; and **outside bodies** — human-rights and environmental, the diaspora — still watch. Know which of these you can reach safely — the refusal to yield land, and reaching the outside world, are often the ones left.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The land-taking. The project must expropriate land. *Your opening — the practical one:* a community's refusal to consent to displacement, a real obstacle.

The water and sovereignty. *Your opening:* the public case against drowning the nation's freshwater and ceding sovereignty.

The courts. *Your opening, where they function:* a legal challenge, tried cautiously.

The outside world. *Your opening, when the space is closed:* human-rights and environmental bodies, and the diaspora, who carry a cause past a closed door.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things — carefully, safely. **Who's behind it and how it's funded** — because a project can founder on its own financing, as the canal did. **What land and water it takes** — the ground the community

can refuse, the freshwater it threatens. **What is safe to do** — because in today's Nicaragua, the risk to you and your community must be weighed before any step.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena — some now dangerous to reach. **Land rights and titles** protect a community's ground. The **courts** can be tried where they function. **International human-rights and environmental bodies**, and the **diaspora**, watch from outside a closed space. And Nicaragua's **communities themselves**, and their **refusal to yield land**, are the force that helped stop the canal — used now with great care.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly — and weigh them against a danger that is now severe. These are rough patterns, not promises, and safety comes before all.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost / risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents (quietly)	5–10%	weeks	low–mod	The base — done safely
Refuse to yield land	30–55%	years	high risk now	A real obstacle to a project
Assert land rights / titles	25–50%	months–yr	mod risk	A community's ground protected
The sovereignty-and-water case	25–50%	months–yr	mod risk	A powerful public argument
Court challenge (where functional)	10–35%	months–yr	mod risk	A decision delayed (rarely)
Reach the outside world	25–50%	months–yr	mod risk	A cause carried past a closed space
Open protest	(was 30–55%)	—	severe risk now	Once possible; now dangerous
Everything together — as in the canal years	35–60% then	years	now severe	A project faced down (2013–)
In today's closed space	lower	—	severe	Weigh every step against the danger

The levers that once moved the needle most were the **refusal to yield land**, the **sovereignty-and-water case**, and a **sustained rural movement**. The canal shows the ceiling (a megaproject faced down, not a stretch dug) and the honest floor (the canal also collapsed on its own financing, and — far more gravely — the open space that allowed a hundred marches is gone). So aim for what is realistically safe: documenting harm, refusing consent where you safely can, using land rights and the courts where they function, and reaching the outside world — never at the cost of your safety.

On cost: the greatest cost now is not money but risk. What was possible in the canal years — open, sustained protest — can today bring arrest, exile, or worse. Weigh every step against that danger, and put your safety and your community's first.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this land-taking, this water threat, this safe step — is strong. Answer five questions in writing, privately.

1. What is it, and how is it funded? Name the project, the company, the government's role, and the financing — because a project can founder on its own money, as the canal did.

2. What land and water does it take? The **ground it must expropriate** (which a community can refuse) and the **freshwater it threatens** (the sovereignty-and-water case) — **the refusal to yield land is your most practical lever**, as with the campesinos.

3. What is safe to do? Before any tactic, assess the **risk** to you and your community in today's closed and dangerous space — because safety comes first.

4. What still functions? Whether **land rights, titles, and the courts** still hold any ground for you, and whether **outside bodies and the diaspora** can be reached.

5. Who's your community — and can it act safely? The **campesinos and residents** whose land and water are at stake, and an honest, careful read of what they can do without unacceptable danger.

What this looks like in real life. A megaproject would expropriate land and drown the nation's freshwater, backed by the government's prestige, in a now-closed space. The five questions yield: the company and its financing (a possible weak point); the land it must take (which the community can refuse) and the water it threatens; a hard assessment of what is safe; whatever land rights, courts, and outside allies still function; and a community that must act with great care. That's the canal pattern — root it in land and water and refusal — but weighed, now, against a danger the canal years did not carry.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can resist and one that can't is proof — gathered safely. Build it in three layers, quietly.

Layer one: the land and water taken. Document the **land the project would expropriate** and the **freshwater it would drown** — the ground the community can refuse, the water the nation depends on — with evidence and testimony, gathered without exposing people to danger.

Layer two: the harm and the case. Document the **harm** — the displacement, the environmental damage, the threat to sovereignty — and the **project's own weaknesses**, including its financing, as the canal's collapsed.

Layer three: the safe channels. Identify what still functions — **land rights, the courts, outside bodies, the diaspora** — and the **safe ways** to reach them. Walking to a functioning court, an outside body, or the world with documented harm — safely — is what still works in a closed space.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The land and water taken** — the expropriation, the freshwater threatened — gathered quietly.
- **The harm** — the displacement, the environmental and sovereignty damage.
- **The project's weaknesses** — the financing and other flaws.
- **What still functions** — land rights, the courts, outside bodies, the diaspora.
- **The safe channels** — the ways to act and reach allies without unacceptable danger.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; a community rooted in its land gives you the obstacle that faced down the canal — but organising now carries grave risk. Build in four moves, cautiously.

Root it in land, water, and refusal. The canal was faced down by campesinos who would not consent to displacement. Root any effort in the community's land and water, and in the practical, powerful refusal to yield the ground the project must take.

Protect people first. In today's Nicaragua, this comes before every tactic: assess the risk, protect identities where needed, avoid steps that expose people to arrest or exile, and never let a tactic outrun what is safe.

Use what still functions — land rights, courts, outside allies. Where **land rights, titles, and the courts** still hold, use them; where they don't, reach the **outside world** — human-rights and environmental bodies, the diaspora — who can carry a cause past a closed space.

Build quietly and durably. Build trusted relationships, a secure and hidden archive, careful ways to decide and communicate, and outside allies — with the endurance for a long fight and the discipline to keep everyone safe.

STEP 4: LAND, WATER & SAFE RESISTANCE

Nicaragua's remaining levers root in land and water, and must be used with care in a closed space.

The Refusal to Yield Land — the Practical Lever

The canal lever: a project that must **take land** depends on people who can **refuse to consent** to displacement. Campesinos who would not yield their ground were a real, practical obstacle that helped make the canal impossible to force through. This refusal — used carefully — remains a community's most concrete lever.

Land Rights and the Sovereignty-and-Water Case

Where **land rights and titles** still hold, they protect a community's ground. And the **sovereignty-and-water argument** — a project drowning the nation's great freshwater reserve — is a powerful public case, at home where it can be safely made, and abroad.

The Courts and Reaching the Outside World

Try the **courts** where they still function, cautiously. And when the space at home is closed, **reach the outside world** — international human-rights and environmental bodies, and the diaspora — who can watch, pressure, and carry a cause past a closed door.

The Honest Limits — Safety First

Straight talk: the canal was faced down in an open space that no longer exists. Today, independent movements are crushed, leaders jailed and exiled, civil-society groups outlawed, and peaceful protest can bring arrest, exile, or worse. So the first rule is **safety** — protect yourself and your community before any tactic — and the realistic aims are documenting harm, refusing consent where you safely can, using land rights and the courts where they function, and reaching the outside world. Count harm documented, land held, a case carried out to the world, and — above all — people kept safe as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it — safely, and often outward.

Displacement becomes a refusal. Not a plea but a fact: *"we will not consent to being swept off our land,"* as the campesinos refused.

A canal becomes a threat to the nation's water. *"They would drive a canal through Lake Nicaragua, the nation's great freshwater reserve."*

Repression becomes a case for the world. *"Peaceful people defending their land are jailed and exiled — the world must see this."*

A project's weakness becomes its undoing. *"This scheme cannot even fund itself,"* as the canal could not.

Match it to the venue — and the safe channel: the refusal and the land rights where they function; the sovereignty-and-water case to the public where it's safe, and to the world where it isn't; the repression and the harm to international human-rights bodies and the diaspora.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In today's Nicaragua, the safest and often only real audience is **outside** — international human-rights and environmental bodies, the diaspora, the world's press — because the space at home is closed and dangerous. Reaching outward is the media strategy.

Lead with the land, the water, and the human cost, not procedure. "They would drive a canal through our lake and off our land — and jail those who refuse." Use your strongest material: the freshwater threatened, the land taken, the human cost of both the project and the repression.

Work the outside audiences above all. International human-rights and environmental bodies, the diaspora, and the world's press can watch, pressure, and carry a cause a closed space would silence. Reach them by safe channels. Make it easy: clear, verified evidence, and safely-gathered testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit a cause in a hostile environment. And protect people first — never publish or share what could expose someone to arrest or exile.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; protect identities; keep any copy secure. In a closed space, prefer safe, often outward channels.

8A — To an international human-rights body.

Subject: Land defenders at risk — [project/place], Nicaragua.

"We report that [project] would [take our land / drown our water], and that those who oppose it face [arrest/exile]: [specifics, safely stated]. We ask your protection and attention. [Secure contact.]"

8B — To an international environmental body.

Subject: A threat to [Lake Nicaragua / place].

"We report that [project] would [drown the nation's freshwater / destroy this land]: [specifics]. We ask your attention and support. [Secure contact.]"

8C — Asserting land rights (where safe/functional).

Subject: Our land and title — [place].

"We hold [land rights/title] to [place], which [project] would expropriate: [specifics]. We do not consent, and we assert our rights. [Contact.]"

8D — Court challenge (to a lawyer, where courts function).

Subject: Legal challenge — [project].

"We seek to challenge [project]'s [concession/expropriation] where the law still allows: [specifics]. We ask your careful advice. [Secure contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To the diaspora / solidarity networks.

Subject: Carry our cause — [place].

"We, [community], face [project and its harms], in a space where we cannot speak freely. We ask you to carry our cause where we cannot. [Secure contact.]"

8F — Recording a refusal (carefully).

Subject: We do not consent — [project].

"We, the community of [place], record that we do not consent to being displaced by [project]: [specifics]. [Contact, as safe.]"

8G — To the international press (safely).

Subject: A canal through our lake, and the jailing of those who refuse.

"[Project] would [drown our freshwater / take our land], and its opponents face repression. We can provide verified evidence and safely-gathered testimony. [Secure contact.]"

8H — Within the community (secure).

Subject: Our land, our water, our safety.

"[Project] threatens our land and water. The canal was faced down by refusing to yield — but the space is closed and dangerous now. Let's protect each other first, and act only as safely as we can. [Secure contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order — safety first:

- 1. Assess the danger, and protect yourself and your community before anything.**

2. **Document the land and water taken, quietly (8F).**
3. **Refuse consent to displacement where you safely can (8F).**
4. **Assert land rights and try the courts where they still function (8C/8D).**
5. **Reach the outside world — human-rights bodies, environmental bodies, the diaspora (8A/8B/8E).**
6. **Take verified evidence to the international press, safely (8G).**

Even lean, those six root in land and water and reach outward — safely — the canal's lesson, adapted to a closed space.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Nicaragua's system is now tilted hard toward a state that crushes dissent, so plan for it, and prioritise safety.

When the space is closed and dangerous. This is today's reality. Protect yourself and your community first; avoid open protest, which can bring arrest or exile; and work through the safest channels, often outward.

When institutions are captured. The courts and independent bodies often serve power. Use them only where they still function for you, cautiously, and lean on outside human-rights and environmental bodies and the diaspora.

When a project must take your land. Even in a closed space, a community's **refusal to yield land** is a real, practical obstacle, as the canal showed. Use it carefully, rooted in your rights and your unity.

When you can reach the world. The outside world — human-rights bodies, environmental bodies, the diaspora, the press — is often the audience that still matters, and can carry a cause a closed space would silence. Reach it safely.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Nicaragua's mega-concessions — a fifty-year canal grant with sweeping powers to a single foreign company — are a study in capture, so this matters; but expose it only as safely as you can.

How to spot it. Sweeping concessions and expropriation powers to a favoured company; a project driven by the government's prestige against the public interest; independent scrutiny crushed; benefits to the connected while communities lose land and water.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Domestic guardians are largely captured. So the real watchers are now **international human-rights and environmental bodies**, the **diaspora**, and the **world's press** — and, where they still function, the **courts** and **land-rights** protections.

How to fight it safely. In a closed and dangerous space, safety comes first. Document precisely and factually, protecting identities; route serious evidence to international bodies, the diaspora, and trusted journalists through secure channels, rather than confronting a hostile state directly. Keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect, and never let exposure endanger anyone.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, and safely. The documented harm builds your case; the refusal to yield land is the practical obstacle; the community is the muscle; land rights, the courts, and outside bodies press it; the world's attention carries it. Together they multiply. But in today's Nicaragua, **safety governs the whole timeline** — no step is worth arrest, exile, or worse.

Early on (quietly): assess the danger; document the land and water taken; root the effort in the community; identify what still functions and what is safe.

In the thick of it (carefully): refuse consent where safe; assert land rights and try the courts where they function; reach outside human-rights and environmental bodies and the diaspora.

The long haul (safely): carry the cause to the world; hold land where you can; and, above all, keep people safe — counting harm documented, land held, a case carried out, and people protected as wins.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Nicaragua was shown to be possible in an open era — farmers in rubber boots, refusing to yield their land, helped face down one of the largest megaprojects ever proposed in the Americas, and not a stretch of the canal was dug. Hold both truths. Nicaragua's distinctive power, as that fight showed it, is real: a sustained rural movement rooted in land, water, and sovereignty, and a community's refusal to consent to displacement, can make even a government's prestige project impossible to force through. And the constraints are now grave: the canal also collapsed on its own financing, so the movement met a faltering project; and — far more seriously — the open space that allowed a hundred marches is gone, replaced by a state that crushes independent movements, jails and exiles leaders, and can meet peaceful protest with arrest, exile, or worse.

Here's the discipline that fits today's reality. Safety comes before every tactic: protect yourself and your community first, and never let a step outrun what is safe. Root any effort in the community's land and water, and in the practical, powerful refusal to yield the ground a project must take — the lever that helped stop the canal. Use land rights and the courts where they still function, cautiously; document harm quietly; and, above all, reach the outside world — international human-rights and environmental bodies, the diaspora, and the world's press — who can watch, pressure, and carry a cause a closed space would silence. Count harm documented, land held, a case carried out to the world, and people kept safe as the wins that matter. That is the canal's lesson — land, water, and refusal — carried now with the care a closed and dangerous space demands. So can you.